

In a September poll of likely voters by the **McCourtney Institute for Democracy**, 64 percent of Harris voters strongly agreed that “Democracy may have problems, but it is the best system of government.” Only 48 percent of Trump voters strongly agreed. Fifteen percent of Trump voters, compared to fewer than three percent of Harris voters, disagreed.

The poll also asked respondents to choose among three options: (a) “Democracy is the best political system in all circumstances,” (b) “In certain circumstances a dictatorship could be a good thing,” or (c) “Whether we live in a democracy or under a dictatorship makes no difference to people like me.” Nine percent of Trump voters chose “dictatorship could be a good thing.” Another 6 percent chose “no difference.”

When analysts combined the two questions, they found that 32 percent of Trump’s voters either (1) didn’t agree that democracy was the best system, (2) said dictatorship could be good, or (3) said it made no difference which system they lived under. The proportion of Trump voters who expressed weak or no support for democracy was double the proportion of Harris voters who did so (16 percent).

Breaking rules.

In October, a *New York Times/Siena College poll* asked likely voters whether presidents should (a) “do what they think is best, even if that might go outside of existing rules” or (b) “follow existing rules, even if that prevents them from doing what they think is best.” Thirty-one percent of Trump voters, compared to 12 percent of Harris voters, said presidents should “go outside of existing rules.” Again, that’s about one in three.

Suspending the Constitution.

In October, a *Monmouth University poll* asked: “If Donald Trump did suspend some laws and constitutional provisions if he is elected president, would that bother you a lot, bother you a little, or not bother you at all?” Nearly 60 percent of registered voters said it would bother them a lot. But 40 percent of Republicans and 32 percent of Trump voters said it wouldn’t bother them at all. Only 25 percent of Republicans and 28 percent of Trump voters said it would bother them a lot.

This finding illuminates a second tier of voters who might go along with authoritarianism. In addition to the third of Trump’s supporters who affirmatively want a rule-breaking strongman, another third or more indicate that they won’t complain much if he openly violates laws and the Constitution.